

Seurat and Signac

Moving on from the apparent spontaneity of Impressionism, Georges Seurat's (1859–91) structured, analytical system of painting, juxtaposing dots of pure colour across his canvases, altered the direction of modern art. Trained at the École des Beaux-Arts, Seurat copied Old Masters in the Louvre and was especially influenced by Rembrandt and Goya. After seeing the 1879 Impressionist exhibition, he recognized the possibilities of breaking with Academic tradition. He began studying colour theories, producing over 500 drawings in Conté crayon that explored tonal contrasts and soft contours. His large-scale work, *A Sunday Afternoon on the Island of La Grande Jatte* (1884–86) used his scientifically based innovations to create shimmering effects. In 1884, he helped to form the Société des Artistes Indépendants and befriended Paul Signac (1863–1935). His dabs of pure colour inspired Signac, who abandoned the short brushstrokes of Impressionism and also began experimenting with Divisionism. After Seurat's early death, Signac continued painting in the vivid Divisionist style for the rest of his career.



Seurat, *A Sunday Afternoon on the Island of La Grande Jatte*, 1884